NeuroSpace — Design Documentation

Ishita Sarin · October 2026

NeuroSpace is an immersive website set in 2081, where every memory you live can be recorded, shared, edited and kept forever by a company called mémoire. Instead of explaining that world, the site puts you inside nine people it has already changed, a minute or two each, so you feel what it costs them.

The brief

The world asks one question: if memory can be recorded, shared, edited, sold and kept, what makes a memory yours? The website had to make a stranger feel that question in a few minutes, with me not in the room.

NeuroSpace started as a written world for *Rehearsing the Future*. A neural implant records everything you live. Eyes have become living cameras. Memories carry smell, touch and emotion, not just pictures. A company called mémoire stores all of it and sells subscriptions, sharing plans and edits under the slogan “Build your own eutopia”.

The idea underneath is a reversal. My protagonist’s generation was afraid of losing memories. The next generation has the opposite problem: too much memory, too many versions, and no way to tell which ones are really theirs.

That gave the website five requirements I kept returning to:

- **Feel, don’t explain.** People should feel a little scared and a little moved, not read an essay.
- **Show the essence first.** Within seconds a visitor must understand that memories here can be shared, bought and edited.
- **Stay short.** Each life takes a minute or two. Nothing is compulsory.
- **Work without me.** It will be shared as a link, so every screen must say who you are, what is happening and what to do.
- **The technology is genuinely wonderful.** Nobody in the world hates it. Every harm comes from a convenience someone chose.

How it got here

The site went through four versions, and every turn came from the same test: would a stranger get it with nobody beside them? Each version is listed with what was wrong with it and what I changed.

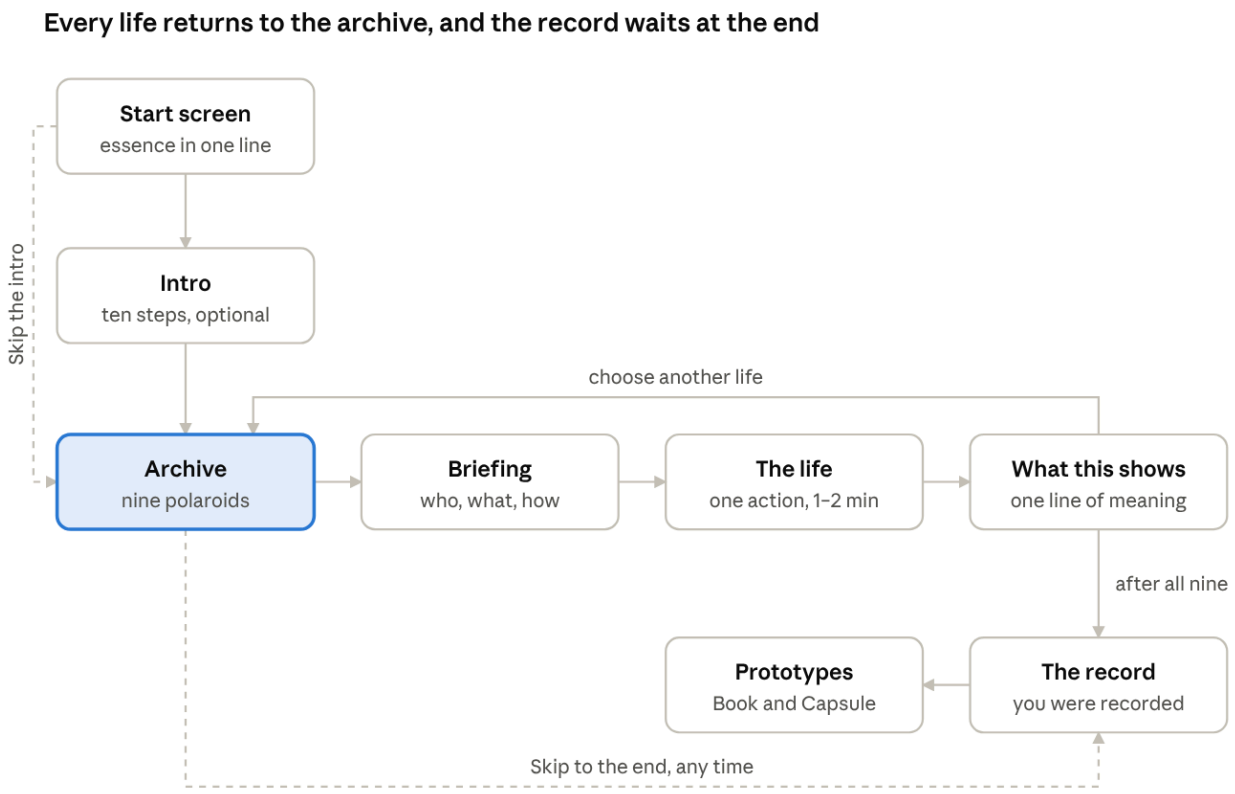
Version	What it was	What was wrong	What I changed
Prototypes (Sept)	Odeur and Cinq Sens as physical devices; Memory Book and Memory Capsule as working apps	They showed how you would retrieve a memory, not what the world does to people	Kept them as evidence, and moved the story into the lives

Version	What it was	What was wrong	What I changed
1. Case-study site	A scrolling page, “Nothing is lost”, describing the world and the prototypes	It explained the world instead of putting you in it. I hated it	Started again as an immersive 3D world meant to unsettle
2. First 3D world	A space-like interface; nine lives as slides you had to go through	The essence never landed. The space look felt generic. Nine compulsory slides were tiring. The Broker was confusing	Rebuilt the frame around memory as a physical object
3. The archive	Start screen that states the essence; skippable explainer; nine polaroid cards; a briefing before each life; Broker rebuilt with visible fragments	The intro could not be paused or rewound; some lives still needed me to explain them	Kept the structure and tightened the story
4. Current	Intro you click through, story arrows in every life, Replay intro, prototypes linked at the end, all nine lives rewritten	Still to test with real visitors	See the sections below

The biggest lesson: every time I described the world, people stayed outside it. Every time I gave them one person and one action, the world explained itself.

Experience map

The archive is the centre of the site. You can leave any life and come back to it, and you reach the end whenever you choose.



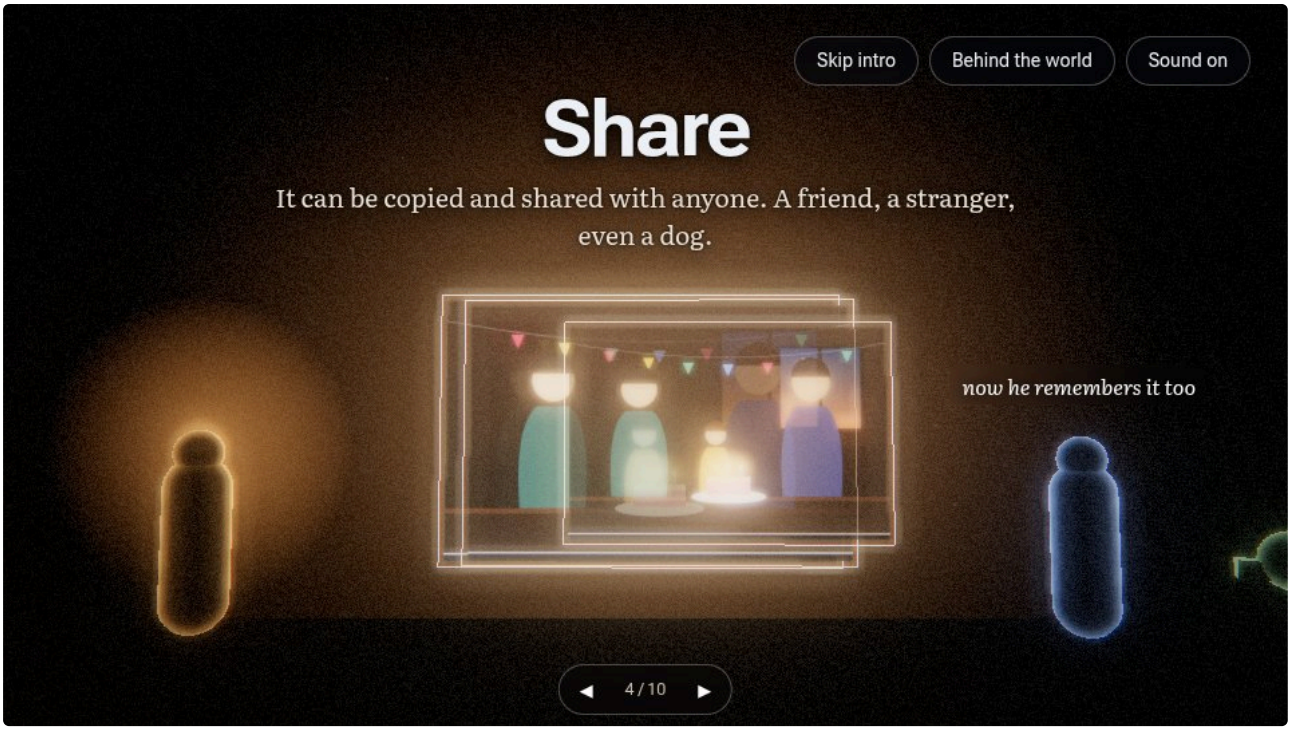
Experience map

Dashed lines are shortcuts that are always visible: Skip the intro on the start screen, and Skip to the end in the top bar. Replay intro, in the archive and on the final card, leads back to the beginning.

The intro

The intro teaches the whole world in four verbs, Record, Share, Edit, Keep, using one memory: a mother's memory of her son's 7th birthday. It is ten short steps and takes about a minute.

1. **2081.** Just the year, large, to set the distance.
2. **"Roughly sixty years from now. The world is in the middle of a change."** Two glowing figures and a dog stand in the dark.
3. **Record.** A frame appears above them: the birthday, with bunting and a cake. It is labelled "one memory: her son's 7th birthday".
4. **Share.** Copies fly out of the frame to the man and the dog. "Now he remembers it too." The dog is there on purpose, because two lives later the dog receives a memory.
5. **Edit.** A scan line passes through the picture and the father disappears.
6. **Edit, continued.** "She remembers it the new way. She cannot tell."
7. **Keep.** The frame shrinks into a wall of thousands of cells. "Nothing is deleted. Only flagged."
8. **"It will not feel like a disaster. It will feel like a convenience."**
9. **"Nine people are already living inside it."**
10. **"Choose a life."**



Intro, step 4: the birthday memory is shared with the man and the dog

Why one memory and not many: a single birthday is something everyone has. Watching the father vanish from it lands harder than any paragraph about editing.

Why click-or-wait: in version 3 the intro just played, and people who read fast were stuck waiting. Now it plays by itself, but a click anywhere, the right arrow or ▶ moves you on, and ◀ takes you back. A counter (3 / 10) shows how much is left. “Skip intro” is always visible, and “Replay intro” in the archive brings it back for anyone who skipped and got lost.

Visual language

The look is built on one idea from the world: in 2081 the old ways of keeping memories survive as relics. So the interface borrows from photographs and film, and the 3D scenes look like a memory replaying in the dark.

Polaroids for the archive. The nine lives sit as instant photos on a dark table, each slightly tilted, each with a small painted scene. A photograph is the last memory technology people could hold and lose. After you visit a life, it is stamped “lived” in red, like an evidence tag.

People as glowing outlines. Figures have no faces or clothes, just a soft rim of light. They read as recordings rather than people, and anyone can see themselves in them.

Film, not screens. Every frame passes through grain, a vignette, slight colour fringing and bloom. When something goes wrong the image glitches or washes red. When a memory ends it fades to white, like an overexposed photo.

A colour per life. Each life has its own light, so you know where you are at a glance, and the archive card, the briefing and the scene all share it.

Two voices in the type. The story speaks in Literata italic, a warm serif, like someone remembering. The system speaks in Roboto Flex, a plain sans, like a notification. You can tell who is talking before you read it: a person, or mémoire. Lines that turn the story go red.

Token	Colour	Used for
Night	#0A0809	Background of every scene
Paper	#EFE4D0	Polaroid cards and briefing
Memory	#FFE9C8	The human voice in subtitles
Amber	#FFB454	Warm memories, labels, the Teacher
Alarm	#FF4D4D	The cost, the crime, the turn

Interaction

Each life has one action, and the action is the argument. You are not told what the system does to people; your hand does it, and then the life shows you what you did.

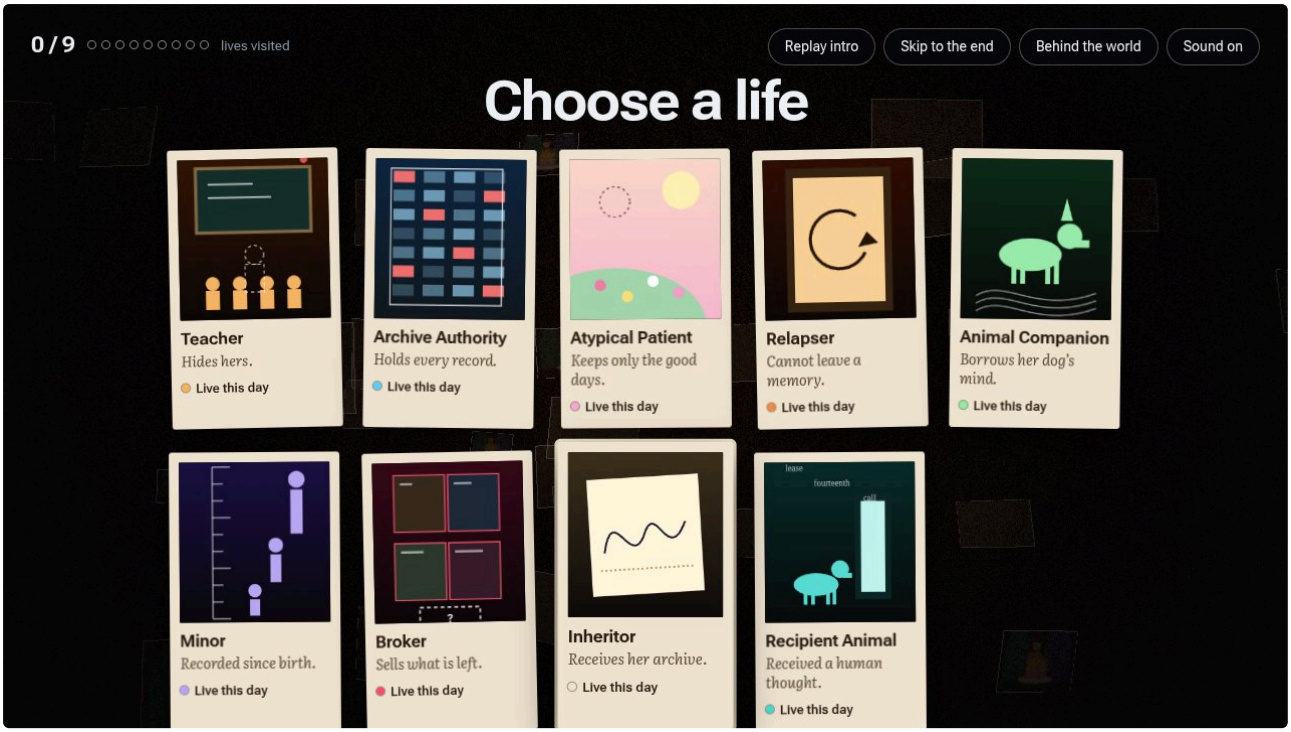
Three verbs cover all nine lives, so nobody has to learn controls twice. A **tap** is a decision. A **hold** is effort over time. A **drag** is learning with your hand.

Life	Your action	Why that action
Teacher	Tap a child to seal their memory	Each tap feels kind and small. Six of them add up to a crime
Archive Authority	Tap glowing memories, then sort by time or day	Surveillance as tidy admin work: pulling, sorting, filing
Atypical Patient	Tap dark memories to delete them	Deleting is one click and feels like relief, until you need the words
Relapser	Hold to leave the memory	Leaving takes effort. Letting go of the button is how you stay
Animal Companion	Tap to enter; press Leave when you choose	You decide how long to stay, and a live counter shows what it costs you
Minor	Hold to move through your years	Your whole childhood passes under your thumb, already watched by others
Broker	Tap fragments, then Generate	Assembling a fake memory feels like shopping, which is the point
Inheritor	Drag over a dotted signature	Your hand learns her hand. Later, one tap signs as her
Recipient Animal	Hold to walk	Every step forward teaches you something human and takes time from you

The instruction text adapts to the device: “Click” and “Hold the mouse” on a laptop, “Tap” and “Press and hold” on a phone.

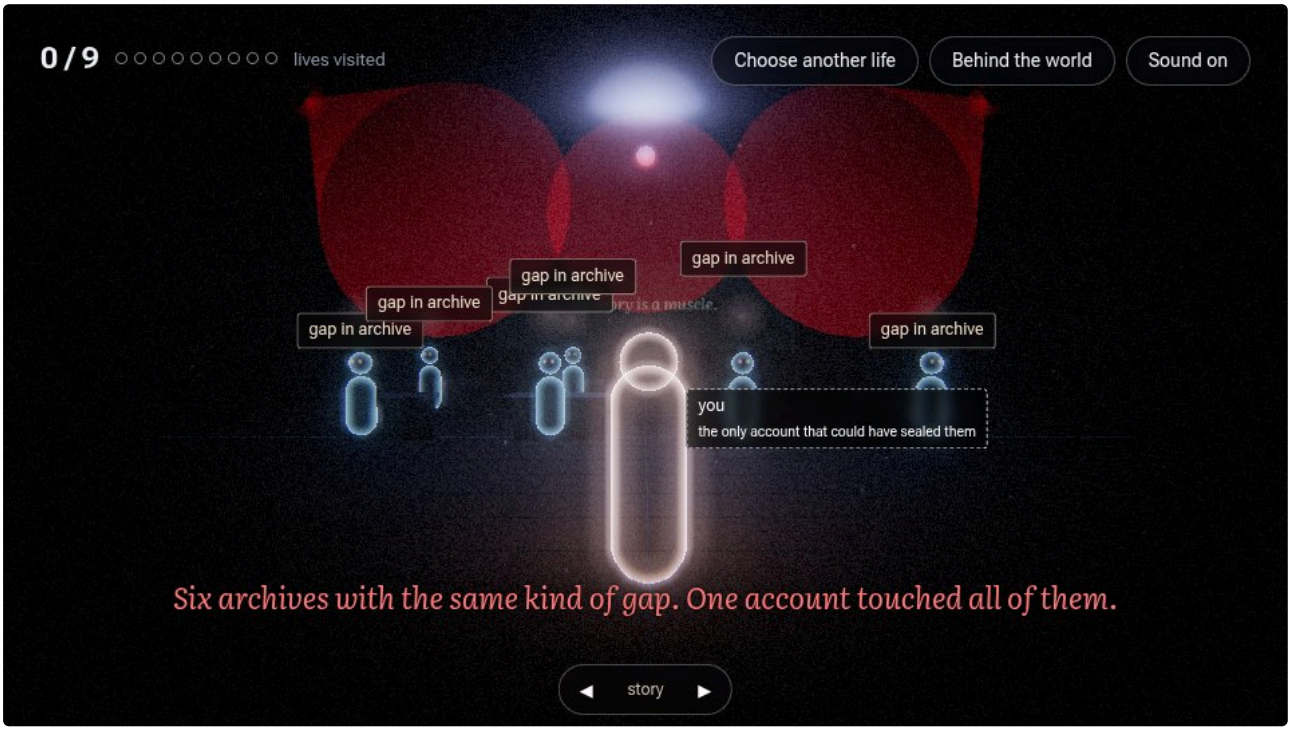
The nine lives

Each life takes one feature of the technology and follows it to the person it hurts. None of them has a villain; each harm starts as something someone wanted. Together they cover the four verbs from the intro: some lives are about recording, some about sharing, some about editing, and all of them about keeping.



The archive: nine polaroids, one per life

Teacher — hiding to protect

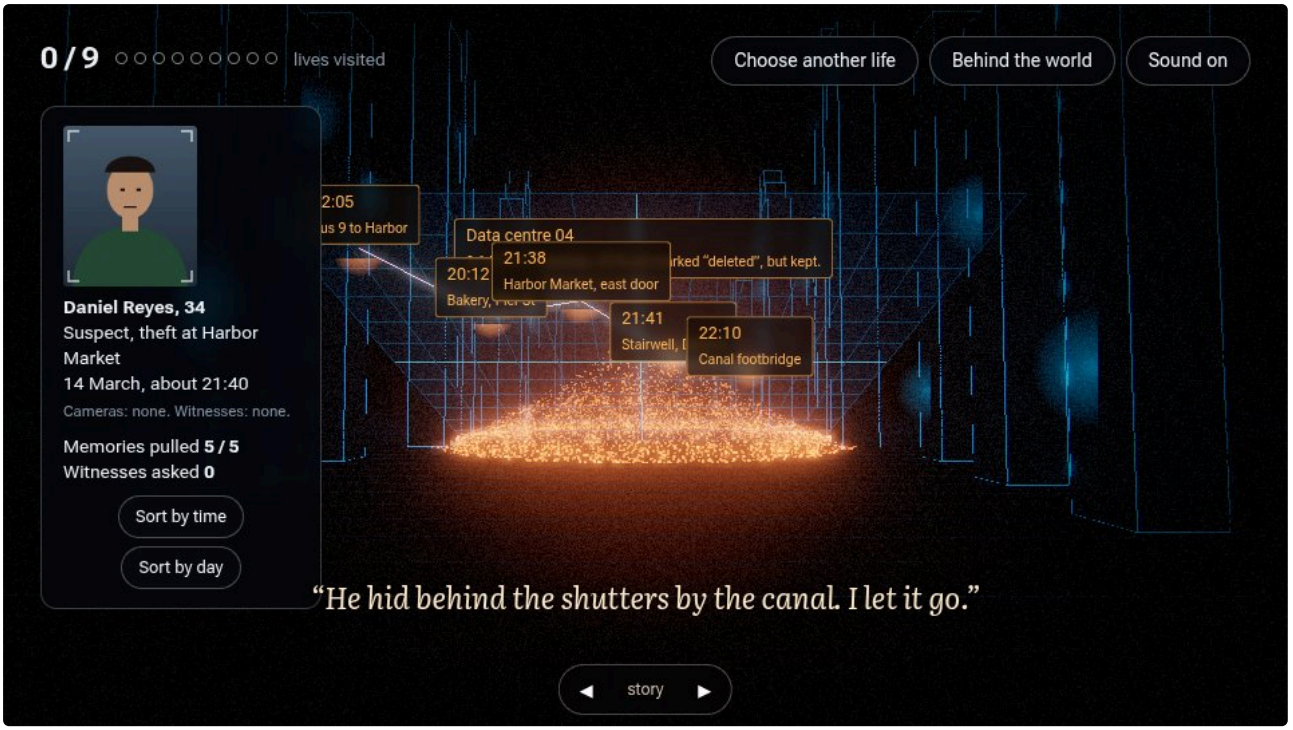


Teacher: the audit finds six gaps and one account

At 18, every child unlocks their whole archive. A teacher has seen what some of hers lived through: a parent leaving, being hit at home, months of bullying. She is afraid they will relive it in full, so she seals those memories. You tap each child, and the red light over them goes out. Then a routine audit finds six archives with the same kind of gap, and one account that could have made them all: yours.

Why: the teacher is my world's protagonist, the generation that remembers when forgetting was normal. I wanted her kindness to be the crime. In a world where everything is recorded, even protection leaves a trace.

Archive Authority — everyone is a witness

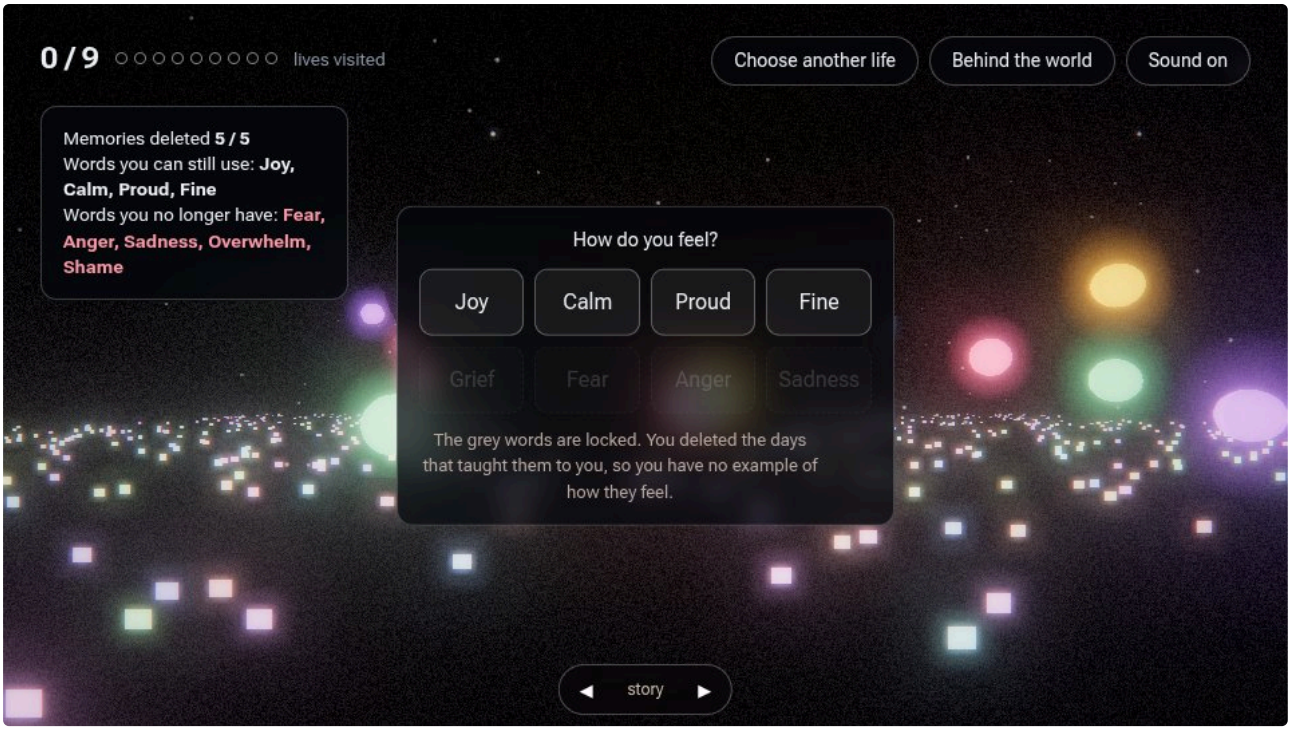


Archive Authority: rebuilding the suspect's route from deleted memories

You run the archive and you are helping the police. There is one suspect, Daniel Reyes, and his photo sits in your panel. Behind it is data centre 04, where 61% of 2.1 billion memories are marked "deleted" but kept. The glowing points are deleted memories of strangers who walked past him. You pull five in, sort them by time or by day, and his route draws itself across a map. Nobody testified. Then one more fragment glows close to you: deleted this morning, from your own account.

Why: surveillance here does not need cameras. The photo makes the target a person, the sorting makes it feel like ordinary office work, and the last fragment turns the watcher into a witness too.

Atypical Patient — deleting the hard days

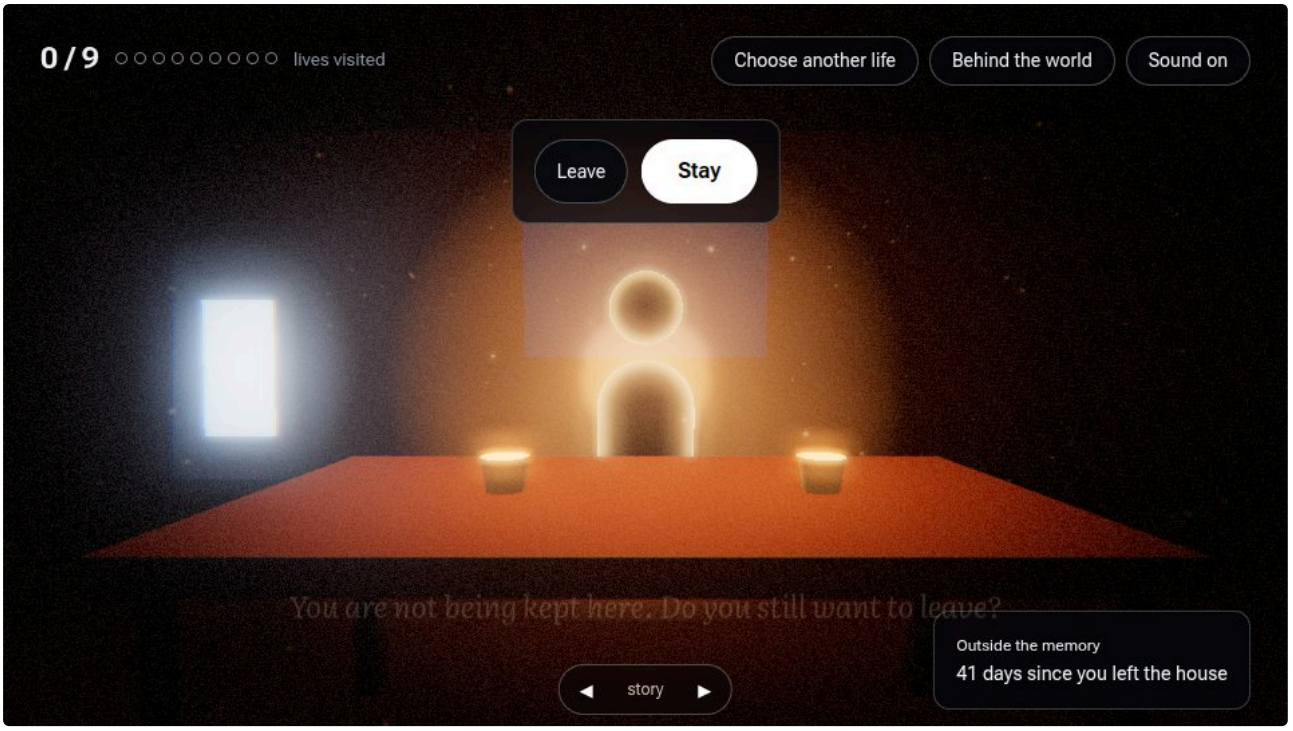


Atypical Patient: the feeling wheel with the hard words locked

You feel and learn differently from most people. For you, hard days are how you learned what feelings are called. Each dark memory is labelled with what it taught you: the loud party taught you overwhelm, the exam you failed taught you shame. Your wellness plan offers to delete them, and a panel tracks the words you lose with each one. Then your grandmother dies and the app asks how you feel. Only Joy, Calm, Proud and Fine are left to choose.

Why: I made it more explanatory after feedback by showing what each memory taught, so the loss is visible before the ending. The wheel makes the point without a sentence: you cannot name what you never practised.

Relapser — choosing to stay

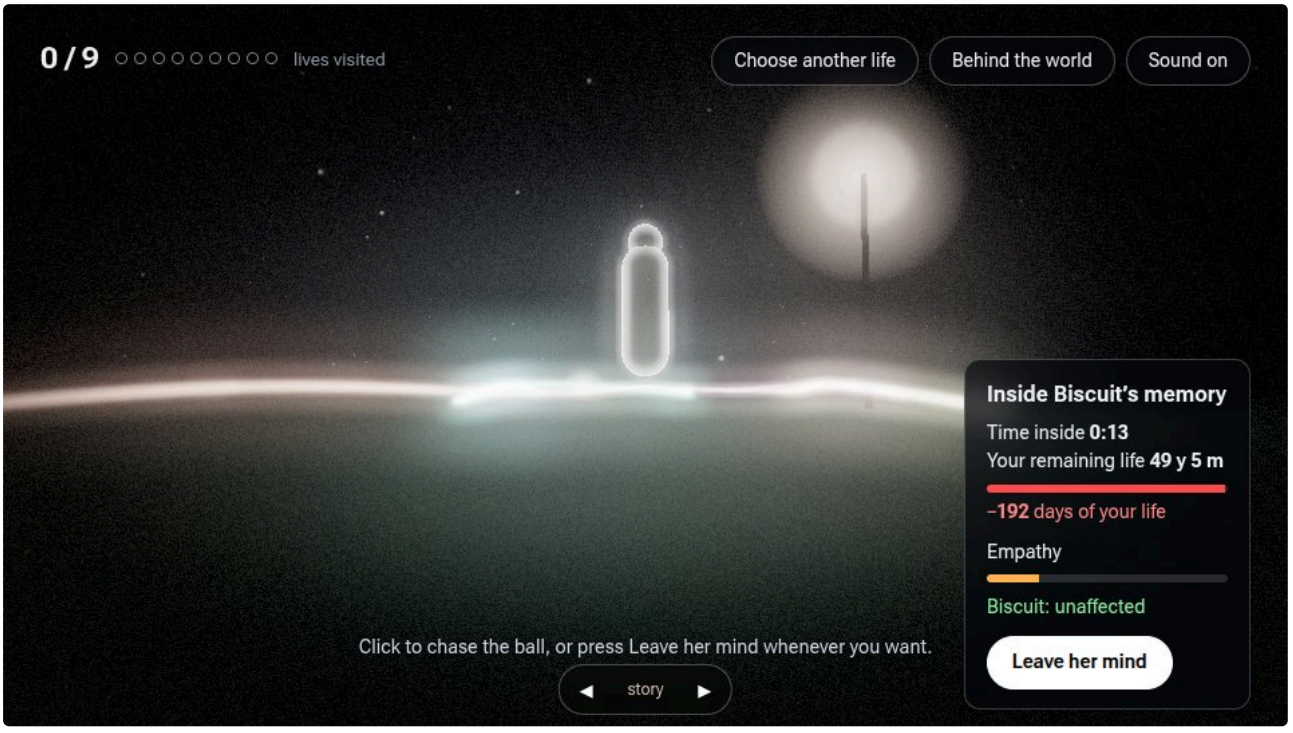


Relapser: the kitchen, the door, and the choice

A man relives a kitchen and his late wife’s laugh. He has promised his family to log out. You hold to walk to the door, and when your hand lets go he drifts back. Nobody is pulling him. Finally the life asks you directly: Leave or Stay. A small panel counts the days since he left the house.

Why: in an earlier version it looked like the system was trapping him. That was too easy to blame. Now the only force keeping him there is his own grief, which is more honest and more frightening.

Animal Companion — empathy costs you

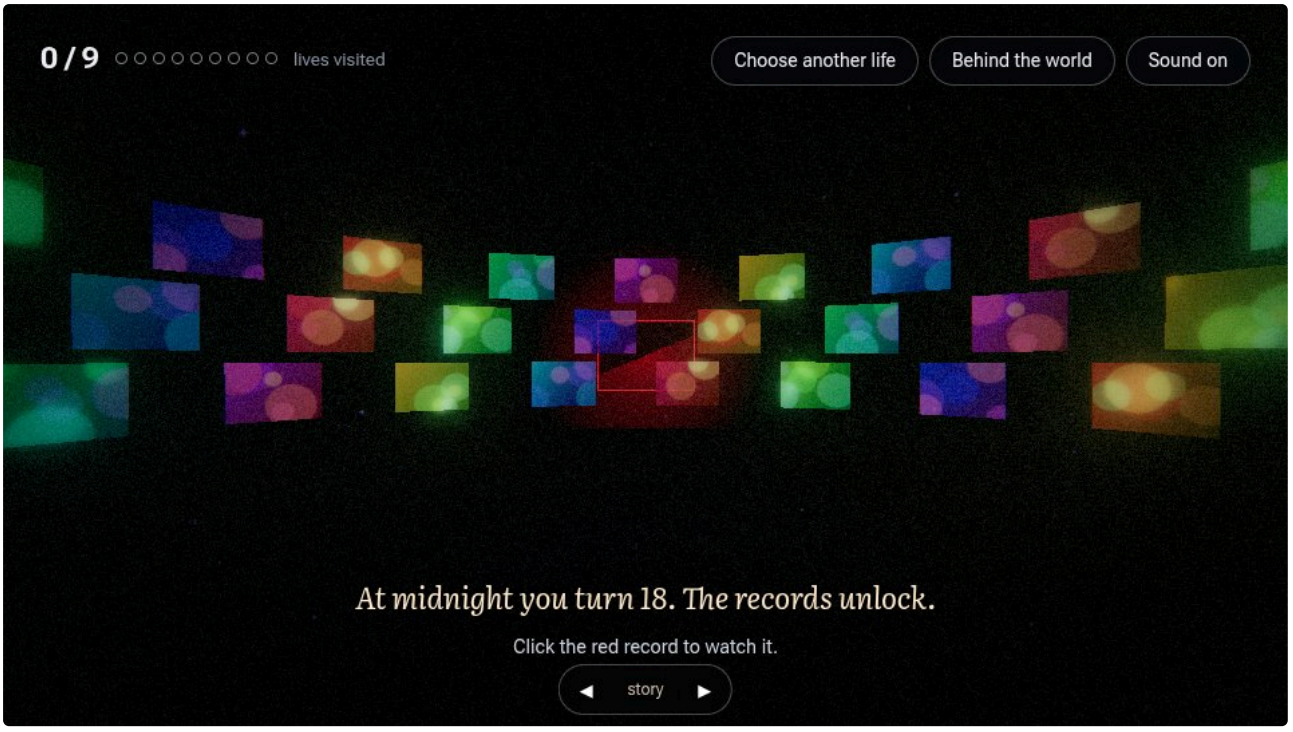


Animal Companion: time inside, life remaining, and the Leave button

Your old dog Biscuit has a pet plan that lets you borrow her memories. Inside, everything is smell and size and home. A panel shows how long you have been inside, your remaining life ticking down, and “Biscuit: unaffected”. The Leave button is always there. When you come out, the life tells you exactly how many days it cost.

Why: at first the cost fell on the animal. I changed it so the reader pays, because then staying becomes your decision and the timer becomes the experience. Some people will leave at once, some will stay to chase the ball.

Minor — a childhood everyone has seen

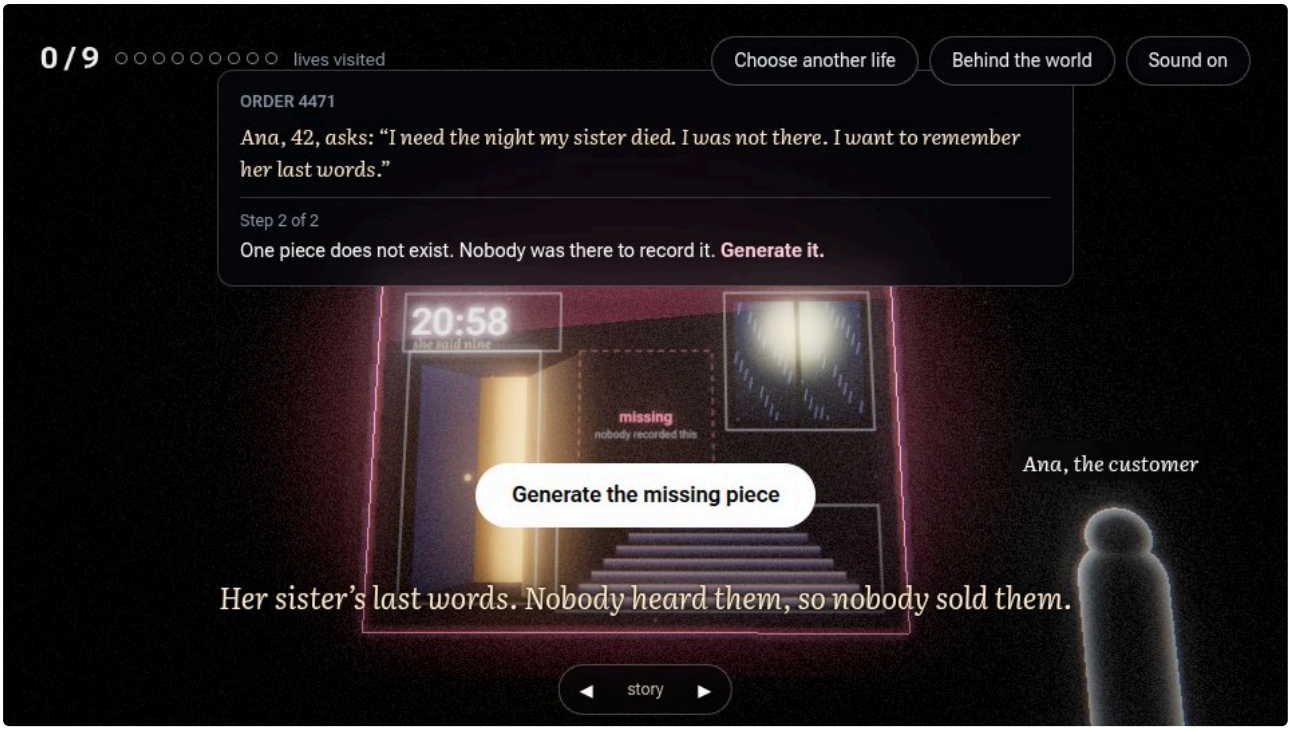


Minor: seventeen years of recordings, two marked disputed

You are 17 and have been recorded since birth. You hold to walk through your years while counters show how many hours of you exist and how many times your parents, school and the government have watched them. Your own count stays at zero. At midnight you turn 18 and the records unlock. Two are marked disputed: your parents are in a custody fight, and each recording of the same night says the other one shouted. Both are real. One has been edited.

Why: the first version was confusing because it had no event. Now it is about the night the records become yours, and the first thing you find is that your own past is evidence in someone else’s case.

Broker — selling what never happened

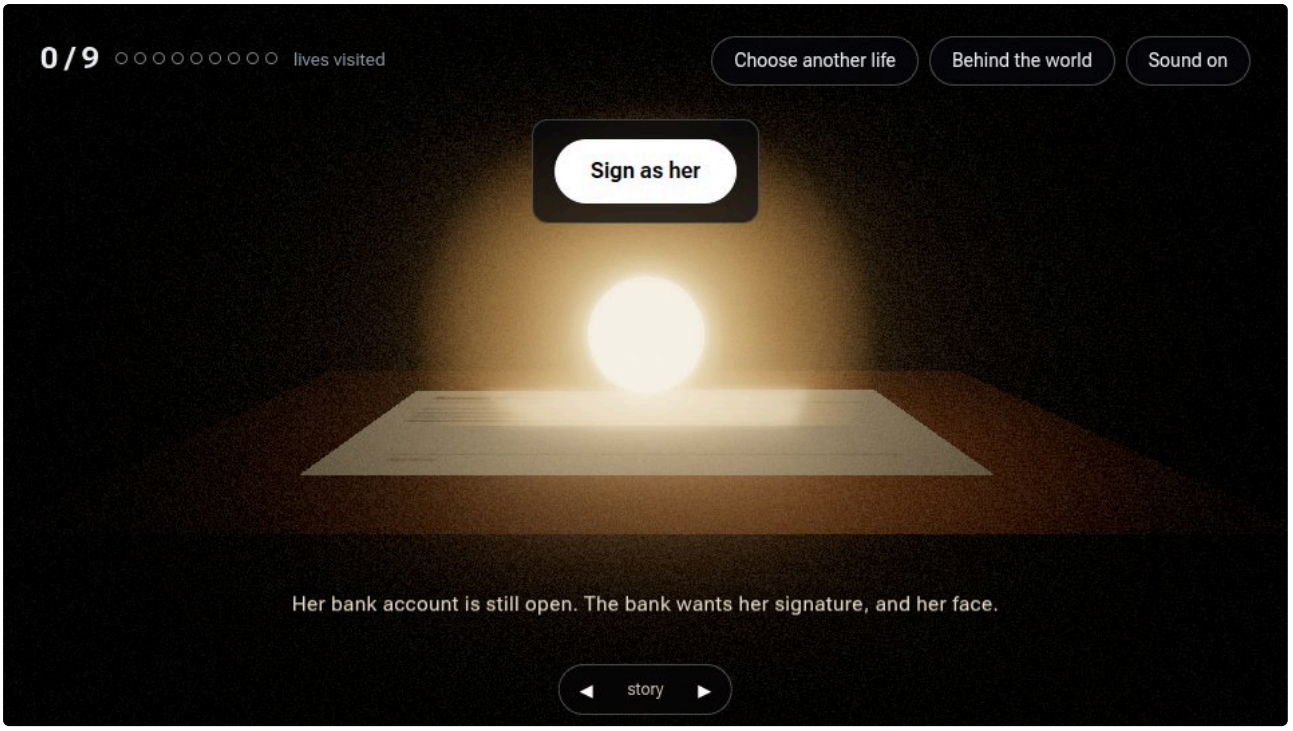


Broker: Ana's order and the missing piece

A customer, Ana, walks in with an order: "I need the night my sister died. I was not there. I want her last words." Real fragments sold by strangers sit on shelves on both sides: an open door, the time on a clock, rain on the glass, a stairwell. You buy four and they fly into her memory. One slot is empty because nobody heard the last words. You press Generate. It looks exactly like the others. "That is exactly how it happened," she says, and a receipt shows who sold each piece.

Why: this was the most confusing life in version 2, because you could not see what the broker was selling or to whom. Adding Ana and her order gave the trade a face, and seeing the fragments fly in made the economy visible.

Inheritor — a hand you can forge

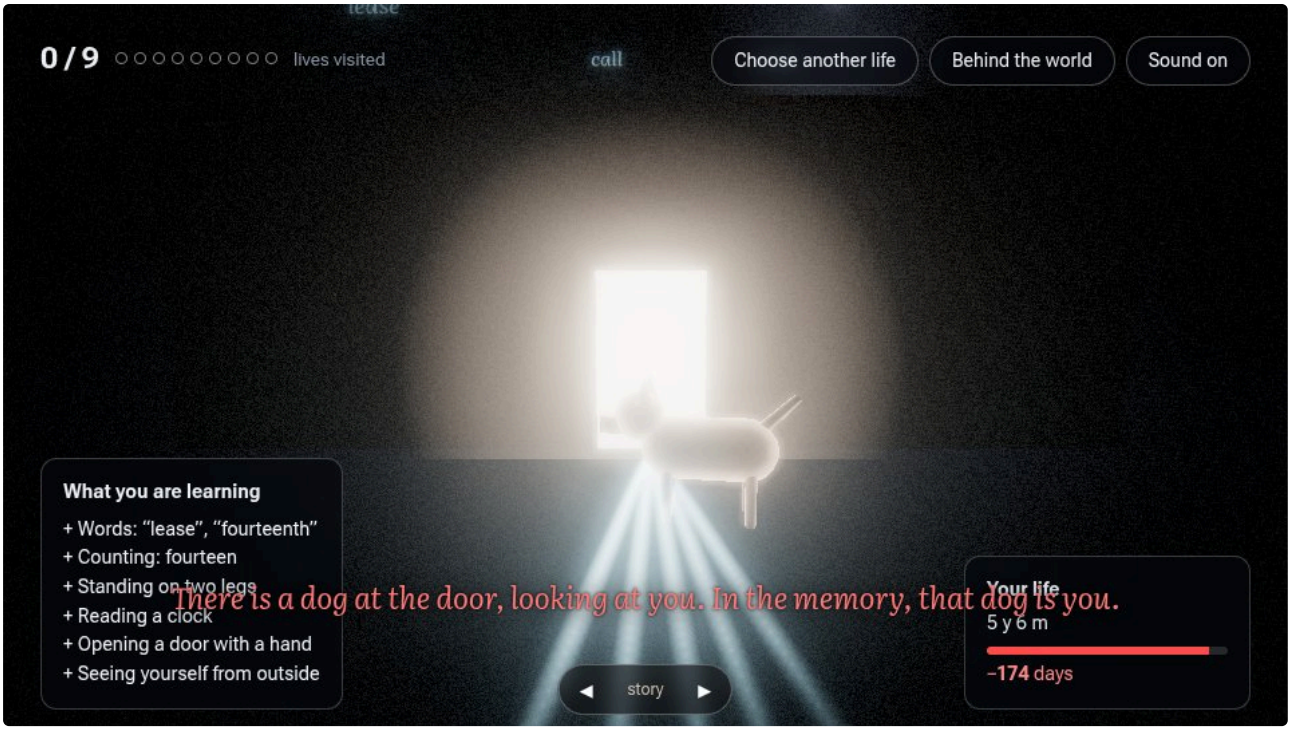


Inheritor: the bank wants her signature and her face

You never went to school. You grew up at your mother’s table, watching her sign everything, and people said you looked just like her. You drag over her dotted signature until your hand knows it. Years later her archive passes to you, and a panel fills with what you now know: pharmacology, contract law, French, accounting, piano. Then the bank asks for her signature and her face. You sign. 99.2% match. Accepted.

Why: inheritance is usually about money. Here it is knowledge, and knowledge you can use as someone else. The signature is drawn by your own hand, so the forgery is yours.

Recipient Animal — a borrowed human mind



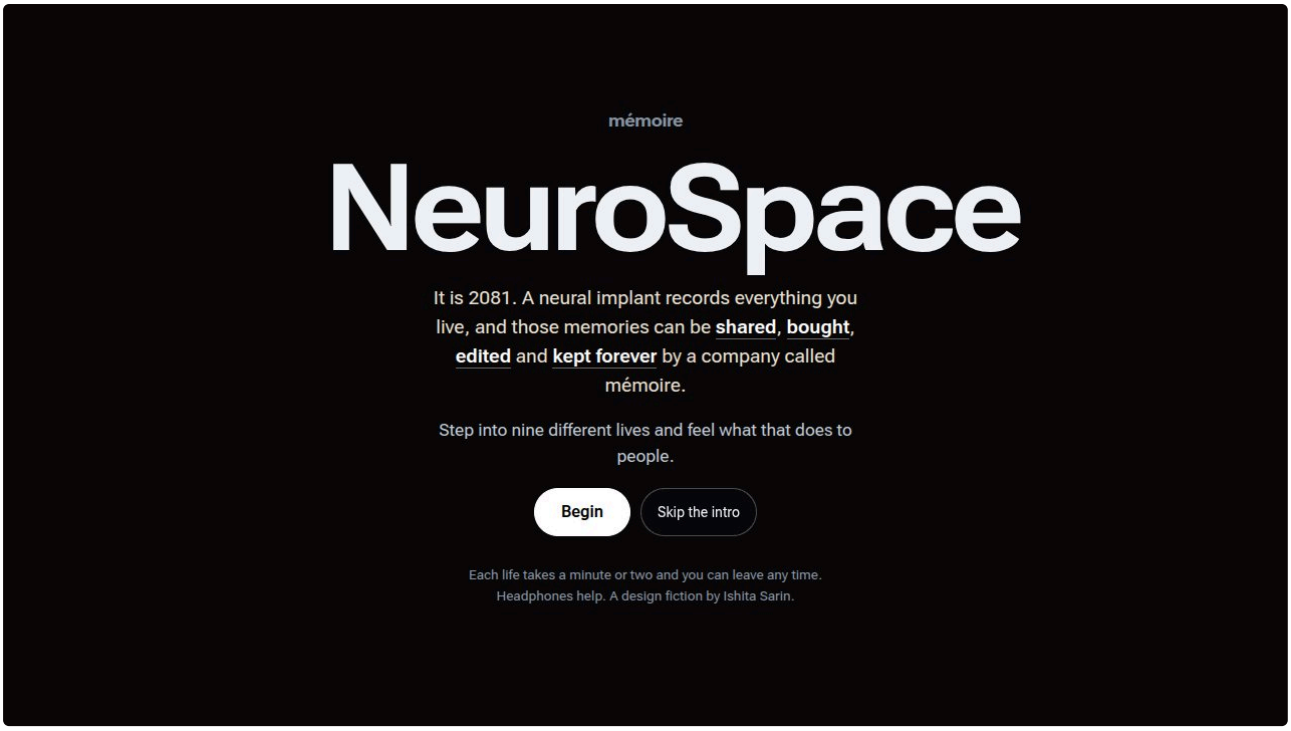
Recipient Animal: what the dog learned, and what it cost

You are a dog, and your owner has sent you one of her memories. You hold to walk toward the door. As you go, a panel lists what you are learning (words like “lease”, counting, standing on two legs, opening a door with a hand) and another shows your life shrinking. At the door you stand like a person, and in the memory you see a dog looking back: yourself, from the outside. You know the lease ends on the fourteenth. You no longer remember what a ball is.

Why: this mirrors the Animal Companion. There, the human pays to feel like a dog. Here, the dog pays to think like a human, and gains skills it never asked for while losing the things that were its own.

Making it self-explanatory

The site has to work as a link sent to a stranger, so every screen answers three questions before the visitor has to ask them: who am I, what is happening, what do I do?



Start screen: the essence in one sentence

The start screen states the world in one sentence. “It is 2081. A neural implant records everything you live, and those memories can be shared, bought, edited and kept forever by a company called mémoire.” The four verbs are underlined because they are the whole world. Earlier versions left people to work this out for themselves.



Briefing before the Teacher’s life

A briefing before every life. It always has the same four parts: You are, What is happening, Your task, Controls. The layout never changes, so after one life visitors know where to look. Each life also ends with a card called “What this shows”: one sentence of meaning, so nobody leaves wondering what the point was.

Words on the scene, not in a manual. Labels sit on the objects they describe (“painful memory”, “the day you deleted”, “Ana, the customer”). A hint line under the story says the next action, then disappears once you have done it.

You set the pace. Story lines move on their own, but the ◀ story ▶ bar at the bottom (or the arrow keys) goes back a line or skips ahead. Fast readers are not held hostage, and slow readers can rewind.

Nothing is compulsory. The archive says it plainly: “You never have to see all nine.” The intro can be skipped and replayed. “Choose another life” and “Skip to the end” are always in the top bar. The counter of lives visited is there for people who want it, not a progress bar to complete.

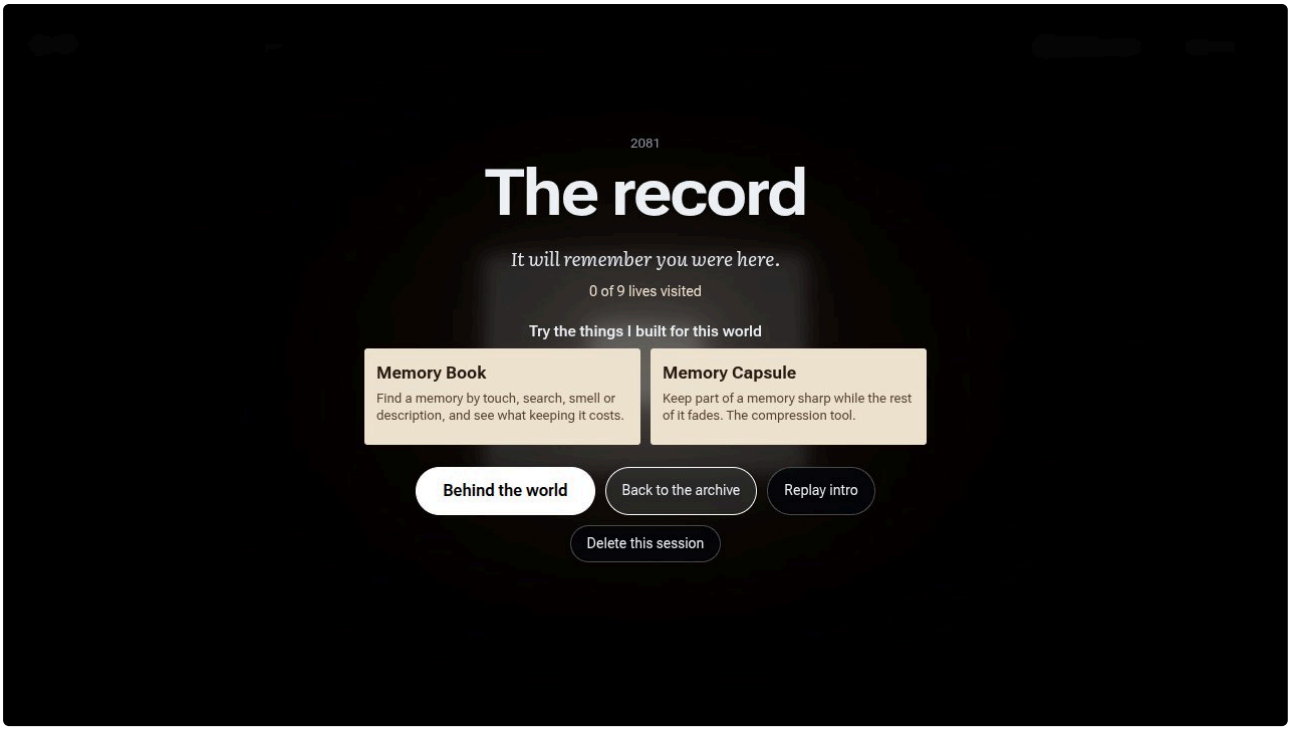
Behind the world is always one click away for anyone who wants the full context: the premise, the physical prototypes and what failed.

Sound, the ending and the prototypes

The ending turns the site on the visitor: you were recorded too.

Sound. Every sound is generated live in the browser, so nothing is downloaded. Each life has its own low drone that crossfades as you move between them. On top sit a few signals people already know: a heartbeat when the stakes rise, a glitch when something is edited, a soft chime when a memory is shared, a murmur of voices, and a laugh in the Relapser’s kitchen. Headphones are suggested on the start screen but never required, and there is a Sound on/off button in the corner.

The record. When you choose “Skip to the end”, or finish all nine, the floating memories collapse into one record. The lines that follow count what you saw: “Recorded. Shared. Edited. Kept. None of it needed a villain. Only convenience. You were here. That is in the record now.” If you saw none of the lives, it says “You chose not to look. That is in the record too.”



The record: the final card with both prototypes

Delete this session. The final card has a button to delete your visit. Pressing it flashes red and replies “Flagged for review. Not deleted.” It is the last thing the world teaches, and the visitor learns it by trying.

The prototypes. The final card links to the two things I built earlier, so visitors can use the technology after feeling its cost:

- **Memory Book** finds a memory by touch, search, smell or description, and shows what keeping it costs.
- **Memory Capsule** keeps part of a memory sharp while the rest fades, the compression tool.

The order is deliberate. If people tried the prototypes first, they would judge them as products. After the nine lives, they use them knowing what they are for.

Built with, and what I would test next

The site is a static website with no build step, so it can be hosted anywhere as a plain folder. All nine lives run start to finish without errors in a test browser. It has not yet been tested with real visitors.

Built with

- **Three.js** for the 3D scenes, bundled inside the folder so nothing loads from outside.
- **Plain JavaScript modules**, one file per life, so each life can be changed without touching the others.
- **One words file** (`roles.js`) holds every briefing and every “What this shows” line, so the writing can be edited without touching code.
- **Literata and Roboto Flex**, self-hosted.
- **Web Audio** for all sound, generated live.
- A film-style post-processing pass for grain, vignette, bloom, glitch and the red wash.

What I would test next

1. **The cold link test.** Send the link to five people who know nothing about the project and watch without speaking. Can they say what the world is after the start screen alone?
2. **Which lives people choose first**, and how many they visit before stopping. This tells me whether the polaroid titles and hooks are doing their job.
3. **Whether anyone finds “Delete this session”**, and what they say when it refuses.
4. **Phones.** The layout adapts to small screens, but the 3D scenes and labels need checking on real devices.
5. **Sound**, on headphones and on laptop speakers, to see whether it adds fear or just noise.

The open question that stays with me is the one the world started with: whether forgetting is a flaw or part of being human. The site does not answer it. It only makes you feel what happens when forgetting is no longer possible.